Tata Steel's winning the award convinced Ratan that his strategy was efficacious. From an embarrassing 19.7 per cent marks, the company had crossed the 60 per cent grade in five years—an achievement made more significant because of its size and the extent of transformation across various segments and departments that was required to make the grade. It convinced Ratan that if Tata Steel could achieve the benchmark, so could others. All that was needed was its earnest adoption by companies. It encouraged him to pursue his restructuring strategies with greater determination.

However, some companies opposed the programme. Despite all his efforts, Ratan faced considerable resistance from some senior leaders. He was aware of the pockets of resistance and strove to tackle them at the root level. He drove home the need for the adoption of this programme during the 2001 award ceremony. At the meeting, he aired his disappointment at some companies questioning why it was needed at all. He responded that he had 'sensed a great deal of cynicism among many people who felt that all this was unnecessary—that it was just a fad'. He sought to impress upon the companies the transformation it could bring about in them and took on the mantle of the chief change agent.

Only he had the stature to convey to the senior leaders that all was not well with the enterprises under their watch. When it came to pushing reforms, he exhorted and implored them to be unremitting in their pursuit of goals. He said that there should be 'fire in our belly', and added, 'never quit, never do the expected, never rest on your laurels, never think great is good enough, never follow', during the 2002 JRD QV Award function. In the following year, he urged the senior managers to make the companies 'lean' and 'aggressive' and stand out 'as being paragons'.

There was also a transformation in Ratan himself—he no longer requested change; he ordered it. The 2004 award function will be remembered for the mild-mannered Ratan becoming an uncompromising leader, a no-nonsense charioteer of change.

In the presentation he made at the function, he displayed a photo of a body with a noose around its neck, an image of an execution in World War II, as a metaphor for the consequences of non-performance. It made several business leaders uncomfortable, though. Sensing this, in the following year's address, Ratan showed a sketch instead of two people hung to death.